According to Holsti[27] they are characterized by:

- Organized activities occurring simultaneously in a number of countries.
- Objectives that do not relate to interests within any given territory.
- Component parts that are essentially non-political.

As far as religious non-state actors are concerned, no actor has been so powerful as the Roman Catholic Church, with the Pope as its universal head who is also the head of state of Vatican or the Holy See. Frankel points out that traditionally, the Vatican has been treated as a sovereign state and it maintains diplomatic relations with a number of states, which may also include non-Christian states Vatican or the Pope the supreme head of over one billion acts as Catholics all over the world. The Pope has made pronouncements on a variety of international issues including economic development, abortion, arms control, and the nature of political regimes. However, the non-Catholic Christian churches, organized around 1954 into the World Council of Churches do not play such a massive role nor does any other religion as such.

The other most important transnational actors are those who are economic in character but have a tremendous impact on all aspects of lives of states. They are the multinational corporations (MNCs). MNCs have been defined in different ways. Some see them as a "cluster of corporations of diverse nationality joined together by ties of common management strategy". Others view them as "companies that control production facilities in two or more countries".[28] Whatever way an MNC is defined, it has a presence in the present-day context unperceived of previously by the state-centric thinkers. To name a few of the prominent MNCs: GE, the Daimler–Chrysler, General Motors Corporation (before they filed for bankruptcy after the global recession of 2008), Ford Motor Company, Exxon Corporation, Procter & Gamble, Unilever, Microsoft, IBM, Toyota, Sony, LG, Mitsubishi, Coca Cola, Pepsi Co., and others.

MNCs reflect the increasing globalization of world economy. By their